



Partly sunny 62/39 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 52/39 B24

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 16, 2025 • \$6

Obamacare alternative is cheaper but limited

‘Short-term’ plans touted by Trump officials lack comprehensive coverage

BY PETER WHORISKEY

Robert Hays, an industrial electronics salesman in Arkansas, thought he’d purchased conventional medical insurance. So did Essie Nath, 67, a retired cafeteria worker in Wyoming. So did Martin Liz, 47, a Key West, Florida, chef.

Each enrolled in the kind of private health insurance that Trump administration officials have promoted as an alternative to plans sold under Obamacare.

The difference between the two options became all too clear after Hays, Nath and Liz required surgery: Their cheaper policies left them facing bills of tens of thousands of dollars. Hays is facing bills of \$116,000 for neck surgery required after tweaking his neck while lifting weights; Nath had heart failure and got bills of \$82,000; Liz is stuck with bills of more than \$100,000 for a knee replacement.

“These policies are a horrible idea,” said Ken Swindle, an Arkansas-based attorney for Hays. “People think they’re getting comprehensive medical coverage, but they’re not, and they often don’t realize that until it’s too late.”

With enhanced government subsidies for Obamacare plans expiring this year and millions of Americans facing soaring insurance costs, many are expected to consider enrolling in the kind of “short-term” plans bought by Hays, Nath and Liz.

Unlike most insurance, these plans are not required to cover preexisting conditions or even basic needs such as maternity care and mental health. **SEE HEALTH ON A8**

The nation’s political unease seeps into a Wisconsin village, and residents feel everyday life begin to fray



JOSHUA LOTT/THE WASHINGTON POST

On edge in small-town America

BY RUBY CRAMER
IN PALMYRA, WISCONSIN

CJ’s Coffee n’ Cream was the only coffee shop in town, and Paul Blount sat in the corner of the room, his chair facing the front entrance, his fingers hooked into the sides of a bullet-resistant vest labeled “POLICE,” so that to anyone coming or going, he would be difficult to miss. Paul, 51, believed it was the duty of a police chief in a place as small as Palmyra, population 1,719, to make himself available to the people of the village. And lately in Palmyra, there was a growing sense of unease that he was determined to talk through and, if he could, contain, before it became something dangerous.

It was the day before homecoming weekend, which meant that soon there would be toilet paper streamers in the trees, a football game played under the lights and the largest parade the village hosted all year. The parade, which ran half a mile from one end of Main Street to the other, was a concern. “Given the climate and recent media headlines, we are taking the following precautionary measures for this weekend’s event,” Paul had written to

members of the village board that governed Palmyra. The precautionary measures included the use of a neighboring county’s drone program, to scan the rooftops for threats. “My team and I are proactively preparing for the worst-case scenarios while continuing to hope for the best.”

How had such a feeling reached a place like Palmyra? A dot on the map between Madison and Milwaukee, the village had two bars, one grocery store, two gas stations and acres of farmland. It was about 20 miles from the interstate, making it a place where people said, “If you’re **SEE UNEASE ON A10**

Paul Blount, whose police department was in need of funding, applied for a partnership with Immigration and Customs Enforcement that stirred tensions in a Wisconsin village with a population of 1,719.

Pickleball’s top college players calling foul on Sunday events

BY BEN BRASCH

As an elite pickleball player, Rachel Garff faced a tough choice when she enrolled at Brigham Young University.

The school famously bars its athletes from playing on Sundays, but that’s when collegiate pickleball tournament finals are usually held. Companies that sponsor top pickleball players often want them to play in those high-profile Sunday events.

To qualify for sponsorships, Garff now pays \$2,000 per semester to take nine credits at nearby Utah Valley University. That allows the 25-year-old to compete for UVU’s club team — which plays on Sundays and is ranked No. 4 nationally.

“I do break even on it, but it’s so much work,” the 25-year-old said of her dual enrollment. And Garff is still torn about her choice.

Now she and 1,600 other athletes and fans have signed a petition asking the organizers of college pickleball’s increasingly lucrative and competitive tournaments to stop scheduling play on Sundays. Many of the signers are members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, which not only owns BYU but is **SEE PICKLEBALL ON A15**



TOM BRENNER/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

WHERE THE SKY KEEPS BURSTING

In Appalachia, warming atmosphere may spawn even more intense torrents

MCDOWELL COUNTY, W.VA. — Carol Lester remembers every flood.

The epic one in 1977, when she fled over a mountain with her young children to avoid rising water. The deluges of 2001 and 2002, which left a trail of destruction in this area but somehow spared the modest house she and her husband have shared for more than half a century.

This article is by Brady Dennis, Scott Dance, John Muyskens, Ben Noll, Kevin Crowe and Niko Kommenda

Carol Lester, 73, observes damage outside her home in Raysal, West Virginia, after the creek that runs through her property was blown out during February flooding. **SEE FLOODING ON A12**

But like many others who have spent their lives in the coalfields of southern West Virginia, she had never seen the likes of what arrived on a frigid day this past February. Days of rain sent the Tug Fork River surging from a relatively calm 6.8 feet to a raging 22.7 feet in just 10 hours, filling the river and its tributaries far beyond their banks.

Sudan’s lost children wander a land of death

Aid groups say over 200 have arrived after fleeing mass killings in El Fashir

BY KATHARINE HOURELD
AND HAFIZ HAROUN

The children stumble in from a burned desert of the dying and the dead. They are weak from hunger and filled with horror. And they are alone.

Aid workers say hundreds of unaccompanied children have arrived in the Sudanese town of Tewila in recent weeks after escaping El Fashir, where fighters from the Rapid Support Forces paramilitary (RSF) have carried out mass killings and kidnappings after seizing the city last month. Some children saw their parents killed; others lost them in the chaos of fleeing. There are babies too, some just weeks old, found clinging to the bodies of their parents and brought to the displacement camp by strangers, according to humanitarian groups in Tewila.

Sudan’s civil war, pitting the RSF against the country’s armed forces, has given rise to a historic humanitarian crisis. U.S. officials estimated last year that 150,000 people had been killed, and the bloodletting has only intensified.

Twelve million have been displaced.

The RSF besieged El Fashir for a year and a half — part of a larger campaign to bring the western Darfur region under its control — walling off the starving city to create what researchers described as a “kill box.” When the army abandoned its last positions in late October, more than a quarter million defenseless people were trapped inside, the United Nations estimated, with many more in surrounding villages.

Fewer than 90,000 have escaped, the International Organization for Migration said Wednesday. A communications blackout in the city makes it impossible to determine how many of the remaining civilians have been killed. But there are horrifying clues: RSF fighters have posted videos of their atrocities, survivors have spoken of widespread massacres and the Humanitarian Research Lab at the Yale School of Public Health has analyzed satellite imagery to approximate the scale of the slaughter. One report a few weeks ago detailed earth disturbances consistent with mass graves; another documented what appeared to be the removal and burning of bodies.

Both sides in the conflict have **SEE SUDAN ON A17**

Bloodshed: UAE faces a rising fury over its paramilitary support. **A17**

BUSINESS

Financial apps for kids are altering how parents handle allowance. **B11**

METRO

A school district’s deal to shift to electric buses hits another bump. **B18**



SPORTS

Spirit returns to NWSL championship match by shutting out Portland. **B1**

BOOK WORLD

Louise Penny gives us a tour of her library. Her dogs come, too.



ARTS & STYLE

New Post food critic Elazar Sontag dishes on why he isn’t anonymous.

TRAVEL

Owners grieving pets can find solace in Vermont’s Dog Mountain.

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